

**Language Attitudes:  
Finnish University Students' Attitudes Toward  
Accented English**

**Sociolinguistic Project Report**

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## **Abstract**

This study investigates Finnish university students' attitudes toward accented English, specifically comparing Russian-accented English (RE) and light-accented English (LE). Using the matched-guise technique (MGT), this study collected data from 12 Finnish university students who rated a single female speaker in two distinct accents in English. Subjects evaluated each accent across traits related to solidarity and status. Results indicate that in terms of status-related traits, LE and RE make no significant differences, except that LE received significantly more positive evaluations than RE in the education trait, while RE was perceived as more sincere, showing greater solidarity than LE. Contrary to the initial hypotheses, which anticipated negative attitudes toward RE in both status and solidarity-related traits, given the current geopolitical tensions and international images of Russia. Data reveal nuanced perceptual differences between LE and RE, with clear distinctions in perceived socioeconomic backgrounds linked to the accents.

## **1. Introduction and Background**

In multilingual societies such as Finland, where Finnish and Swedish hold official status, English functions as a *lingua franca*, facilitating communication among individuals from diverse sociocultural backgrounds, especially in academic and business contexts. Kachru (2012) proposed a three-circles model that assists us in categorizing the global use of English based on its social functions and contexts. This model shows not only the complex and dynamic interplays between societies, languages, and identities but also the need to investigate attitudes toward accented English within different language environments, given the widespread use of English globally. However, examining language attitudes toward accented English in multilingual Finland can provide valuable insights into how individuals are perceived and categorized to infer their social identities and backgrounds based on their language use, which in turn, elicits listeners' stereotypic traits (Dragojevic and Goatley-Soan 2022a). Moreover, McKenzie (2008) argues that linguistic preferences can shape and influence individuals' educational success and employment opportunities. These preferences over languages or their varieties, to some extent, inform and influence language policies, guiding decisions that

affect social integration and language preservation within societies.

In recent decades, linguists have begun to pay attention to language attitudes that reflect social power dynamics. Lambert et al., (1960, 44) state that “spoken language is an identifying feature of members of a national or cultural group, and any listeners’ attitudes toward members of a particular group should generalize to the language they use”. Language is not only a human communicative tool but also a mark of group identities. However, numerous studies have been done in various contexts worldwide (Dominic and Hogg 1987; Castelan and Giles 1997; Carina 2013; Zhang 2013; Dragojevic and Goatley-Soan 2022b), for instance. Still, only a few studies (Leppänen et al., 2010; Leinonen 2014; Pirskanen 2014; Jarkko and Posti 2018; Truong 2021) have focused on the context of Finland, which is unique for its language landscapes.

In this study, I aim to uncover Finnish university students’ attitudes toward accented English, Russian, and light-accented English in particular. Russian-accented English (RE) refers to the variety of English spoken by native Russian speakers, characterized by specific phonological features such as a tapped or trilled /r/ (Swan and Smith, 2001). In contrast, light-accented English (LE) denotes speech that is phonologically closer to inner-circle varieties of English, such as British English (Kachru 2012), than to RE. However, subjects' social backgrounds and prior language experiences will be surveyed to assess their influences on the evaluations of these two varieties of English. Additionally, potential gender differences among subjects’ evaluations will also be observed and discussed.

Based on previous studies, I expect that general attitudes toward RE and LE will align with McKenzie’s (2008, 64–65) claim that “standard varieties tend to be judged positively in terms of status, whereas non-standard varieties tend to be evaluated more highly in terms of solidarity”. However, given the current geopolitical tensions and more recent findings (Dragojevic and Goatley-Soan, 2022b), I hypothesize that RE will be rated negatively on both solidarity- and status-related traits compared to LE among the subjects.

## 2. Methods and Data

This study uses the matched-guise technique (MGT) as its primary methodology. “The MGT is an experimental speech perception method to elicit covert attitudes toward linguistic varieties or specific features” (Loureiro-Rodríguez and Acar 2022, 185). Moreover, the MGT is considered the most used research method in the field of language attitudes since it was introduced by Lambert and his colleagues in the 1960s (Lambert et al., 1960). However, this method involves a speaker who can produce several guises in various accents or language varieties. For instance, researchers can ask a speaker to deliver the same message with a British and an American accent. In addition, the MGT is featured by its use of the prescribed text and control over the content that the listeners are exposed to (Nejjari et al., 2019; Loureiro-Rodríguez and Acar 2022). On the one hand, the prescribed text avoids paralinguistic variables that could occur in the recordings that will be played to the subjects. The use of the prescribed text, to some extent, ensures that subjects react to accents rather than to some paralinguistic variables in the speakers. On the other hand, the prescribed text does not allow the speakers to speak as naturally as they do in daily settings. The unnaturalness can influence subjects’ evaluations of and attitudes toward accents in a study (Loureiro-Rodríguez and Acar 2022) (See **Appendix 1** for the prescribed text used in this study). To sum up, the MGT has some apparent advantages and limitations in comparison with the verbal-guise technique (VGT), which involves several native speakers of each language or its variety.

### 2.1. The questionnaire and procedures

A native Russian female speaker was hired and recorded reading a semantically neutral text in two accents (RE and LE). Each recording lasts around 35 seconds to avoid listener fatigue (Penke and Rosenbach 2007). This speaker can be considered as a “representative guise” (Nejjari et al., 2019, 92) based on the personal backgrounds, language experiences, and some phonological features in the recordings. Then, the two recordings representing RE and LE were embedded in a four-point Likert-based Google Forms questionnaire. This questionnaire was designed with eight positive adjectives to

describe individuals' status and solidarity-related traits, including the speaker being friendly, educated, trustworthy, intelligent, confident, gentle, attractive, and sincere (See the link in **Appendix 2** for the questionnaire distributed). The positive adjectives avoid the potential perceptual distractions of the subjects, thus improving the validity of the data collected.

Subjects first listened to one accent (LE) and completed the rating form, then listened to the second accent (RE) and repeated the ratings. They were also asked to assess the speaker's perceived social background, selecting from higher, average, or lower socioeconomic categories. At the end of the questionnaire, subjects had the opportunity to leave comments on either or both accents presented in the study.

## 2.2. The subjects

The questionnaire received a total of 12 responses, with 6 females, 5 males, and one who does not want to disclose. The relatively balanced gender distribution in the collected data allows for the examination of potential gender differences, as discussed in **Section 1**. Among the participants, 92% reported using Finnish at home, 67% had frequently or occasionally known, studied with, or had friends who were Russian speakers, 75% had previously learned Russian to some extent, 50% interacted daily with non-native English speakers, and nearly 60% rated their overall English proficiency as near native or native. Based on the self-reported data, all subjects align with the target group of this study, Finnish university students.

Furthermore, they can be considered "experienced raters," a group typically regarded as more reliable and lenient in judging accents compared to other populations (Thompson, 1991).

## 2.3. Data Analysis

The collected data will be analyzed using a paired t-test, which is ideal for comparing two sets of scores from the same subjects under different conditions. This statistical method is widely used to determine whether the mean ratings for each variety on a given factor differ significantly (Dragojevic and Goatley-Soan, 2022a). Relevant statistical tables and graphs will be generated to present the data analyzed.

### 3. Results

#### 3.1. Status versus solidarity traits of LE and RE

Table 1. Traits-Level Comparison

| Trait              | LE Mean | RE Mean | t           | p            |
|--------------------|---------|---------|-------------|--------------|
| Friendly           | 3.25    | 3.50    | −1.46       | .173         |
| <b>Educated</b>    | 3.58    | 3.17    | <b>2.55</b> | <b>.028</b>  |
| Trustworthy        | 3.42    | 3.50    | −0.46       | .656         |
| <b>Intelligent</b> | 3.25    | 3.25    | 0.00        | <b>1.000</b> |
| Confident          | 3.17    | 3.50    | −1.42       | .185         |
| Gentle             | 2.92    | 3.00    | −0.23       | .822         |
| Attractive         | 2.75    | 2.58    | 1.55        | .150         |
| <b>Sincere</b>     | 2.92    | 3.67    | −2.60       | <b>.025</b>  |

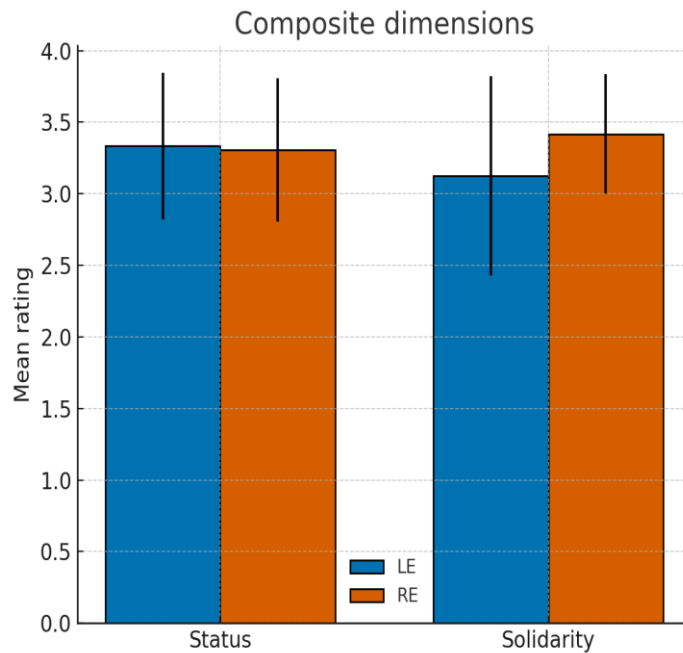
A p-value below .05 = statistically significant difference.

A p-value above .05 = not significant

As mentioned in **Subsection 2.2**, 12 subjects responded to the questionnaire. All subjects completed it correctly and followed the given instructions. The data obtained were analyzed using the statistical method described above. The analysis reveals differences in Finnish university students' perceptions of LE and RE, with some significant distinctions in specific traits, despite an overall limited degree of disparity. In terms of status-related traits, LE was judged significantly more educated than RE, with a p-value of 0.028. This result indicates a statistically significant difference between LE and RE on this trait, supporting the hypothesis that closer phonological proximity to inner-circle varieties of English, such as British English, positively influences perceptions of a speaker's status. Specifically, the findings regarding education level align with McKenzie's (2008) claim that standard varieties tend to be evaluated more positively in terms of status.

Conversely, RE was rated higher than LE on solidarity-related traits, particularly in sincerity. This result also supports the claim that non-standard varieties typically elicit more positive evaluations in terms of solidarity, suggesting that listeners may associate stronger social solidarity traits with accents perceived as less standardized or more closely tied to local identities.

### 3.2. Results in general



In **Section 1**, I hypothesized that, given current geopolitical tensions and findings from more recent studies, RE would be rated more negatively than LE on both solidarity- and status-related traits among the subjects. However, the analyzed data contradicts this hypothesis, showing that, in terms of status, RE and LE received nearly identical evaluations from the subjects. This finding also challenges the expected association between standard varieties and higher status evaluations. Additionally, in terms of solidarity-related traits, RE performed statistically better than LE, aligning with the established association between outer-circle varieties and more positive solidarity evaluations.

### 3.3. Gender differences in evaluations

The study initially aimed to explore gender differences in evaluations; however, the data indicate minor variations, but these variations are not statistically solid enough to be representative, given the small sample size ( $n=12$ ). These evaluation differences between genders in statistics may be inflated (Podesva and Sharma 2014).

### 3.4. Perceived socioeconomic backgrounds

The subjects' assessments of the speaker's socioeconomic backgrounds illustrate great perceptual differences. Approximately half (50%) of the subjects perceived the RE

speaker as belonging to an average socioeconomic background (average education and income), with 17% of them perceiving that the speaker is from a low socioeconomic background. In contrast, LE was more frequently associated with a higher socioeconomic status (41%), compared to only 17% for RE. The data clearly indicate a connection between certain accents or phonological features and perceived socioeconomic status, supporting Dragojevic and Goatley-Soan's (2022a) claim that listeners use accent as a medium for social categorization. Furthermore, Krivonos (2020) demonstrated that even slight Eastern European accents in Finnish or English can expose post-Soviet migrants to racialization and discrimination. These findings further prove that languages and their varieties function not only as communication tools but also as reflections of broader social power dynamics.

#### **4. Discussion**

The hypotheses of this study are partially sustained by the results above, showing nuanced attitudinal differences toward accented English among Finnish university students. The privilege in the educational status trait of LE resonates with the prior study, emphasizing the perceived superiority of the inner-circle English varieties (McKenzie 2008; Kachru 2012). However, the higher ratings in solidarity-related traits for RE, particularly in sincerity, reflect a positive social image and valuation that contrasts with the initial assumption influenced by the current geopolitical tensions. Contrary to the hypothesis predicting broadly negative evaluations of RE on both solidarity- and status-related traits compared to LE, this study found no great differences between RE and LE in terms of status. Moreover, it reveals slightly more positive attitudes toward RE regarding social solidarity.

##### **4.1. Limitations and suggestions for future studies**

Despite the results shown above, several limitations affect the power and generalizability of this study, most notably the small sample size ( $n=12$ ). Additionally, order effects, as discussed by Lambert et al. (1960), might have influenced the reliability of the data and its results. While an attempt was made to control this effect by designing two questionnaires with the reversed recording order embedded in, insufficient responses to the second questionnaire limit this control mechanism.



Moreover, the subjects, characterized as "experienced raters" with high English proficiency and regular contact with non-native English speakers, may differ dramatically from broader Finnish societal attitudes toward RE. Thompson (1991) observed that "experienced raters" tend to be more lenient, suggesting a potential bias toward more positive evaluations of both accents due to familiarity and prior language experiences (McKenzie 2008).

Future studies should employ a larger and more diverse sample population, incorporating subjects with varying levels of English proficiency and a broader range of sociodemographic characteristics. Additionally, measures should be taken to minimize order effects, thereby enhancing the reliability of the data and providing more comprehensive insights into language attitudes within multilingual contexts.

### **The workload distribution**

I have done the whole project independently and individually, from data collection to report writing.

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### **Appendix 1. The prescribed text**

That Thursday morning, I sat down at the beach and set my thick towel on the sand. I was happy to see the weather was warm, though it was a bit windy. I filled my bucket with water for my sandcastle and placed it next to my phone. I brought four sandwich halves because I didn’t know which flavors to pick. Then, while eating lunch, I looked west and saw a stranded whale! It was very heavy, and I thought I couldn’t handle it alone. Without your assistance, I would never have moved it off the shore, so thank you again for helping me.

### **Appendix 2. The link to the questionnaire used**

<https://forms.gle/LAhYn8CywwL9Vgjk7>